

LGTM IS NOT A STRATEGY

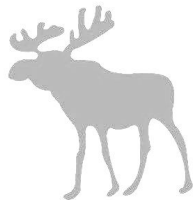
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TODD'S TIMELINE



2000



2007



2010



2015



2021

CGI

2024



I Am Developer ✓

@iamdeveloper



10 lines of code = 10 issues.

500 lines of code = "looks fine."

Code reviews.

4:58 AM · Nov 5, 2013



96



7.1K



5.9K



80



WHY PR REVIEWS MATTER

- Reduce risk
- Share context / training
- Improved maintainability
- Improved quality signals
- Collaborative risk management



**WHAT DOES A
HIGH-QUALITY PR LOOK
LIKE?**

QUALITY BEYOND STYLE

- Correctness
- Safety
- Clarity
- Testability
- Operability



**HOW DO WE MEET
THESE GOALS?**

THREE VIEWPOINTS

- Author
- Tester
- Reviewer





GREAT
REVIEWS
START BEFORE
THE PR IS
OPENED

MY FAVORITE PR DESCRIPTIONS

"stuff"

"push"

"Fixed!"

""

"Addressed comments"



PR DESCRIPTION TEMPLATE

- What / Why
- Scope In & Scope Out
- Risk Level & Why
- Tests performed (unit, integration, manual)
- Rollout plan (flags, migrations)
- Screenshots / logs / metrics

FOCUS ON SMALLER PRS

- Never feature with refactor
- One "theme" per PR
- Hot Take: no more than 6 files

NOT JUST
“TEST AT
THE END”



QA AS CO-REVIEWER

- Acceptance criteria → executable examples
- Negative tests and boundary cases
- Ensure repeatable test steps
- After-release monitoring
- Test data needs
- Environment risks



DON'T
“DRIVE BY”
THE REVIEW



60 SECOND TRIAGE

- Understandable?
- Tests? (or reasons why not?)
- Blast radius
- DB migrations / config / dependencies

RED FLAGS

- “Big bang” PRs
- Unbounded loops / timeouts
- Swallowed exceptions
- Hidden side effects
- Lack of observability
- Flaky tests



REVIEW IN LAYERS

- Intent & requirements
- Design & interfaces
- Readability & maintainability
- Edge cases
- Tests
- Style



LEAVING
COMMENTS
IS AN
UNDERVALUED
SKILL

COMMENT LABELING

- [Blocking] - correctness / security / data loss
- [Concern] - risk / maintainability
- [Suggestion] - improvement / alternative
- [Nit] - style / preference / optional

GOOD COMMENT FORMULA

- "I noticed ..."
- "This could cause ..."
- "Can we ..."
- "Here's an example ..."

TONE & TRUST

- Assume positive intent
- Critique the code, never the person
- Avoid "just", "obviously"
- Avoid hyperbole - "always", "never"
- When in doubt, use a question

TEAM MECHANISMS MAKE IT STICK



TEAM PROCESS & METRICS

Process

- Review SLAs
- Group review for risky changes
- Use CODEOWNERS
- Limit PR size, merge to main

Metrics

- PR size - files, comments count
- Time to first review
- Rework rate
- Test failures after merge

WHY PRS MATTER

Collaborative risk
management

Quality beyond
style

Three viewpoints &
team process

WHAT CAN YOU TRY THIS WEEK?

- Comment labels
- Risks & test plan in PR description
- Review top-down with good comments

THANK YOU!

- <https://google.github.io/eng-practices/review/>
- <https://docs.github.com/en/pull-requests/collaborating-with-pull-requests/reviewing-changes-in-pull-requests>
- <https://smartbear.com/learn/code-review/best-practices/>
- <https://microsoft.github.io/code-with-engineering-playbook/code-reviews/>
- <https://www.atlassian.com/software/bitbucket/tutorials/pull-requests>